

Homepage Discovery Map

This prototype is the **recommendation funnel on Google Maps**. What follows is what that engine can and cannot do. Items that belong on the production site are not listed here.

What this prototype is

A four-level funnel on **Google Maps**:

World (countries) → Country (cities) → City (attractions) → Attraction (products)

Preference chips re-rank pins and the list. Trade-offs and match labels sit next to recommendations. A results panel sits under the map.

It is **not** a Natural Earth world with no third-party branding, a quiet city diagram, or a globe in the same look as the flat map. Those are Google Maps limits, listed below.

Achieved — with constraints

These items exist in the prototype. The limits below are from **Google Maps**, not from missing production work.

Funnel, preference, and honesty

Brief item	What we did	Constraint
Four-level funnel (L0–L3)	Pin/list taps descend one level. Breadcrumbs, controls, and guarded native zoom gestures move through levels.	Native zoom uses a threshold and short lockout so camera animations do not accidentally trigger another level change.
A pin is a recommendation	Only catalogued destinations / cities / attractions get pins.	—
We reorder, we never hide	Every destination stays on the map; match label and copy change with the chip.	—
One entity type per level	World = countries, country = cities, city = attractions. Products and product counts stay in the panel.	—
Preference row — one tap re-ranks	Chips re-rank pins, rewrite labels/copy, reorder the list, update the count line.	Re-tint of recommended countries is an overlay on Google land, not a restyle of Google’s own polygons. Unreliable if Google labels/roads show through.

Brief item	What we did	Constraint
Poor fit returns to World	If the open country, city, or attraction is a poor fit for the new chip, we leave that view.	—
Preference is never a URL	Chip is session state. URL does not change.	—
Transition flash states what changed	Lines such as “Poland · 5 cities prioritised”.	Google tiles can still visibly load.
Pan never changes level	Dragging does not open a country or city.	Google still pans a wayfinding map. The brief’s “not a Google Maps-style wayfinding tool” is not met by the surface itself.
Map failure does not remove recommendations	A poster occupies only the map while Google loads; a no-map message replaces only the map if the API fails.	The recommendation list remains usable, but map interactions are unavailable.

Map levels

Brief item	What we did	Constraint
L0 — country pins, pick counts, match-tier pills	White pills, coloured tier, country name, pick badge.	Not Natural Earth. Google is Web Mercator only.
L0 — warm land, pale water, hairline borders, no roads/labels	The flat map uses Google JSON styling without a Cloud Map ID; roads, POIs, and labels are suppressed; country overlays tint recommended land.	Google’s own geometry remains underneath. Google attribution cannot be removed (terms of use).
L1 — Mercator fitted to the country	Google is already Mercator; we fly to country bounds; selected country is filled darker; city pins are accompanied by low-priority attraction-count clusters.	Neighbouring Google geography remains visible.
L2 — centre, km rings, scale, true coordinates	Centre dot, concentric rings, Google scale control, dotted screen overlay, attractions at real lat/lng.	Surface is still Google’s map , so the dotted field is an approximation rather than a standalone diagram.
L3 — stay at city scale; selected attraction emphasised; siblings tappable	Camera stays on the city; selected pill is emphasised; other attractions stay tappable.	3D markers may hide behind Google’s collision behaviour.

Brief item	What we did	Constraint
Commercial detail arrives late	World/country: counts only. City: rating, reviews, from-price. Attraction: duration, exact price, CTA.	—
Caps 8 / 4 / 3	Code slices cities to 8, attractions to 4, unique products to 3.	—
Pin readability and touch	Flat-map pins use screen-space collision layout, stay inside a control-safe frame, expose 44px hit areas, and progressively drop count/label detail before holding back a crowded lower-ranked pin.	3D uses Google's own collision system.
Touch 44px; never fade text	Pins, mode controls, chips, rows, breadcrumbs, and CTA use 44px-class hit areas. De-emphasis uses fill/border, not faded type.	—

Phase 2 — 3D

Brief item	What we did	Constraint
3D globe with rotation/tilt	A toggle switches to Google photorealistic 3D (or tilted hybrid if 3D fails).	This is Google's 3D tiles , not a RosoTravel globe in the same language as the flat map. Needs extra Google APIs and billing. Country tints and city rings do not appear on the 3D surface.

Cannot achieve on Google Maps

These are limits of the Maps JavaScript API and Google's terms. They cannot be finished on Google Maps. This prototype stays on Google Maps, so these brief items stay as limits.

Brief requirement	Google Maps limitation
Phase 1: Natural Earth projection	Google Maps is Web Mercator only. There is no Natural Earth (or other cartographic) projection.
Own vector geometry , RosoTravel styling, no third-party branding	The basemap is Google's. Attribution (logo and data credits) must stay visible . Hiding it breaks Google's terms.
No provider labels, city names, or roads on the surface	The flat map hides most labels and roads with JSON styles, but Google's basemap geometry, logo, data credits, and legal links remain.
Recommended countries re-tinted as part of the basemap	Overlay polygons can approximate this. They are not Google's own land styling.
L2 as a quiet dotted field (diagram, not a street map)	Google city view is still a map (roadmap, satellite, or hybrid). Overlays do not turn it into the specified diagram.

Brief requirement	Google Maps limitation
Phase 2: globe in the same visual language as the flat map	Google 3D is photorealistic tiles — branded, heavy, not the same look as the flat recommendation map.
“ Not a Google Maps-style wayfinding tool” as the homepage centrepiece	Google Maps remains a wayfinding product even with chrome hidden.

Scorecard

	Status
Recommendation funnel (4 levels, preference chips, trade-offs, match labels)	Achieved on Google Maps
Spec map (Natural Earth, no Google branding, quiet city diagram, matching globe)	Not achievable on Google Maps
Google flat + photorealistic 3D with our pins	Achieved , with the limits above

What we recommend saying

This prototype is the **recommendation funnel on Google Maps**: preference, four levels, honest labels, and a list beside the map. Google Maps cannot be Natural Earth, cannot drop Google branding, and cannot become the quiet city diagram or a globe in the same look as the flat map. We stay on Google Maps and accept those limits.